

IDS 105 Project Template

Identify your chosen scenario.

Work: I am part of my company's hiring team, and we are currently deciding between two candidates. One is a single mom, who some colleagues believe will be more stable because her children are in school and she values health care benefits. The other is a young graduate, who is highly dedicated and works long hours, but whose long-term commitment is uncertain. This has created debate within the team, raising questions of fairness, bias, and what factors should guide our decision.

Part One: Social Justice

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1. Explain the difference between justice, fairness, and equality as they apply in your chosen scenario.

In this hiring scenario, justice means ensuring that the hiring decision is made without discrimination and with respect for the rights and dignity of both candidates. Fairness is about giving each candidate an equal opportunity to be evaluated on their skills, qualifications, and potential, rather than assumptions about their personal lives. Equality refers to treating both candidates with the same standards and criteria during the hiring process. While equality ensures they both receive the same consideration, fairness and justice require that unconscious biases—such as assumptions about a single mom's stability or a graduate's commitment—do not outweigh objective qualifications.

Describe how bias could impact social justice in your chosen scenario.

Bias could **impact social justice in this situation by influencing** the hiring team's perception of the candidates. For example, assuming the single mom will stay longer because of her children may unfairly stereotype her and ignore her actual career goals and skills. On the other hand, assuming the young graduate is unreliable because of their age could lead to discrimination against younger workers. Both forms of bias prevent the decision from being based on merit and perpetuate inequality in the workplace.

Explain how different narratives circulating in society could impact how social justice is perceived in your chosen scenario. These narratives may be on social media, in the news, or among community members.

Societal narratives often portray single mothers as either struggling and in need of stability or, conversely, as being fewer flexible employees. Similarly, young graduates are sometimes stereotyped as highly ambitious but "job-hoppers" with little loyalty. These narratives, spread through media and cultural conversations, could influence how the hiring team perceives the candidates. If unchecked, these assumptions can undermine social justice by reinforcing stereotypes rather than recognizing each person's unique strengths and experiences.

Explain the core principles of social justice in your chosen scenario.

The core principles of social justice in this scenario include equity, respect, and inclusion. Equity means ensuring that both candidates are evaluated based on their skills, experiences, and potential, without being disadvantaged by stereotypes. Respect means acknowledging their individuality rather than reducing them to social categories (such as "single mom" or "young graduate"). Inclusion means creating a hiring process where diverse backgrounds and life circumstances are seen as assets, not liabilities. Together, these principles ensure that the hiring decision promotes fairness and upholds the dignity of all candidates.

Part Two: Elevating Your Cultural Fluency

1. **Describe how cultural fluency benefits your self-awareness.**

Cultural fluency benefits my self-awareness by helping me recognize the assumptions I may carry into decision-making. In this hiring scenario, I might unconsciously assume that a single mother is more stable or that a young graduate is less committed. By becoming aware of how cultural narratives influence my thinking, I can pause and question whether those beliefs are based on facts or stereotypes. This reflection strengthens my ability to separate personal bias from professional judgment. In turn, I grow more mindful of how my background and experiences shape my perceptions, making me a fairer and more objective evaluator.

2. **Describe how to demonstrate cultural fluency in your chosen scenario.**

Demonstrating cultural fluency in this hiring scenario means actively acknowledging and respecting the diverse life experiences of both candidates. Instead of framing one candidate as “more stable” and the other as “less reliable,” I would focus on their qualifications, achievements, and the value they bring to the company. It also involves listening to colleagues’ perspectives and addressing any biases that appear in the discussion. Practically, this could look like using structured interview questions, applying the same evaluation rubric to both candidates, and encouraging the team to reflect on how societal stereotypes may be shaping their judgments. By doing so, cultural fluency ensures that the process is inclusive, respectful, and centered on fairness.

Part Three: Intercultural Communication and Collaboration

1. **Explain how mindfulness of different cultures could improve communication with individuals in your chosen scenario.**

Mindfulness of different cultures could improve communication in my hiring scenario by encouraging the team to pause and consider how cultural narratives may shape assumptions. For example, recognizing that ideas about “stability” or “loyalty” can vary across cultures helps the team avoid applying narrow definitions to the candidates. By being mindful, we can listen with more openness, ask clarifying questions instead of assuming, and make space for multiple perspectives. This reduces misunderstandings and ensures that both candidates are evaluated fairly on their merits rather than stereotypes.

2. **Describe how familiarity with diverse backgrounds can positively influence communication in your chosen scenario.**

Familiarity with diverse backgrounds allows the hiring team to approach candidates with empathy and respect for their unique experiences. For instance, understanding that a single mother may have developed strong organizational and multitasking skills, or that a young graduate may bring fresh ideas and adaptability, helps reframe the discussion around strengths rather than limitations. This familiarity also improves dialogue within the team, as members can recognize their own biases and contribute more thoughtful, inclusive perspectives to the decision-making process.

3. **Explain why an awareness of diversity is beneficial to collaboration in your chosen scenario.**

Awareness of diversity is beneficial to collaboration because it fosters a culture of respect and inclusion within the hiring team. When team members acknowledge the value of different perspectives, they are more likely to work together productively, even when they disagree. In this scenario, awareness of diversity prevents the team from falling into groupthink or relying on societal stereotypes. Instead, it supports balanced discussions, stronger teamwork, and ultimately a fairer hiring decision that aligns with the company's values of equity and inclusion.

Part Four: Communication Strategies to Navigate Conflict

(Complete this section in Module Five. Refer to the conflict in your chosen scenario to respond to the questions below.)

1. **Describe the components of the conflict represented in your chosen scenario.**

The main conflict in this hiring scenario involves differences in opinion and unconscious bias within the hiring team. Some colleagues view the single mother as the more “stable” candidate because of her life situation and perceived long-term reliability, while others favor the young graduate for her dedication and energy. The disagreement stems from conflicting values: some team members prioritize dependability and personal circumstances, while others focus on skill, ambition, and long-term potential. This conflict also reveals potential bias — assumptions about parenting, age, and commitment — which could influence the fairness of the hiring decision.

2. **Describe different interpersonal communication strategies that could help resolve the conflict.**

Several interpersonal communication strategies could help the team navigate this disagreement:

Active listening – Team members should listen carefully to each other's viewpoints without interruption, ensuring they understand the reasoning behind each opinion.

Non-violent communication (NVC) – Each person identifies the event (the disagreement), expresses how it makes them feel, and makes clear requests for how others can respond respectfully.

Empathy and open-mindedness – Recognizing that everyone's perspective is shaped by different experiences helps reduce defensiveness and bias.

Restorative circle discussion – A structured conversation where all voices are heard equally in a safe, neutral space, focusing on shared goals such as fairness and inclusion in hiring.

3. **Choose a communication strategy to resolve the conflict. Include an explanation of why you chose that communication strategy.**

The best strategy for this situation is the restorative circle discussion combined with non-violent communication. This approach creates a neutral, safe space where all team members can express their thoughts openly and respectfully. It supports the principles of restoration (repairing harm caused by bias or misunderstanding), neutrality, and voluntarism described in the course materials. Through this process, each team member can share their perspective without judgment, reflect on potential bias, and work toward a shared understanding of fairness in hiring. This strategy not only resolves the immediate disagreement but also builds trust and empathy within the team.

4. **Describe the potential communication challenges that may arise in your chosen scenario.**

One challenge could be emotional defensiveness if someone feels accused of being biased or unfair. Team members might also struggle with implicit bias — making judgments based on personal experiences rather than job qualifications. Another challenge is power dynamics; if senior team members dominate the discussion, others may hesitate to share honest opinions. Maintaining neutrality and ensuring everyone's voice is valued will be essential to avoid these pitfalls.

5. Describe both the benefits and challenges of using restorative practices to address the conflict in your chosen scenario.

Benefits:

- Restorative practices promote understanding, empathy, and fairness by allowing each person to express their viewpoint safely.
- They can strengthen relationships within the team and build long-term trust.
- The process encourages reflection on unconscious bias and helps the group create more equitable hiring standards.

Challenges:

- It can be uncomfortable for participants to be vulnerable or admit bias.
- Restorative discussions require time, patience, and skilled facilitation to stay neutral and constructive.
- Not everyone may be ready to engage openly, especially if emotions are still high.

Overall, using restorative practices in this hiring scenario allows the team to move beyond personal bias and focus on shared organizational values such as fairness, inclusion, and respect.